



Bolivia

Landlocked high in central South America, Bolivia is one of the region's poorest countries. La Paz is the world's highest capital city: 13,385 feet (3631 m) above sea level.



GEOGRAPHY

A high windswept plateau, the *altiplano*, lies between two Andean mountain ranges. Semiarid grasslands to the east; dense tropical forests to the north.



CLIMATE

Altiplano has extreme tropical climate, with night-frost in winter. North and east are hot and humid.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The indigenous majority faces widespread discrimination. Wealthy Spanish-descended families have traditionally controlled the economy. Amerindian Evo Morales, president from 2005, pledged to cut poverty, legalize coca, and redistribute land.



INSIGHT: Between 1825 and 1982

Bolivia averaged more than one armed coup a year



THE ECONOMY

Gold, silver, zinc, tin, oil, natural gas: all vulnerable to world price fluctuations. Social issues and nationalization of natural gas sector deter investors. Major coca producer. Lack of manufacturing. Rich eastern provinces want autonomy.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Bolivia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1825

CAPITAL: La Paz (administrative);

Sucre (judicial)

POPULATION: 9.86 million

TOTAL AREA: 424,162 sq. miles

(1,098,580 sq. km)

DENSITY: 24 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Aymara*, Quechua*, Spanish*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 93%,
other 7%

ETHNIC MIX: Quechua 37%, Aymara 32%,
mixed 13%, European 10%, other 8%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Boliviano = 100 centavos